

This step-by-step guide will help you prepare your cat for import into Australia from a Group 2 classified country.

You can print this guide and use it as a checklist.

Need to know

This is a complex process. Before you start the import process, we recommend you read this guide in full.

- Allow at least 6 months to complete health checks, tests and paperwork.
- All pre-export preparations and treatments must be completed by a government approved veterinarian in an approved country.
- Fees apply for our services, such as permit assessment and quarantine in Australia.
- There are certain breeds of cats that are prohibited from import into Australia.
- Overseas travel can cause significant stress to animals. If your cat is sick or elderly, consider if this is the right decision for them.

1

We encourage you to use an experienced pet transport agent or shipper.

Importing a cat or dog to Australia is a complex process. It will take at least 6 months to complete. You will need to make sure your cat meets a range of import conditions. This includes multiple veterinary visits, checks and treatments.

Seek help from a pet transport agent with experience in importing cats to Australia. They will help guide you through the import process.

Or you can check industries associations such as:

- [International Pet and Animal Transportation Association \(IPATA\)](#).
- [Animal Transportation Association \(ATA\)](#)

We cannot recommend one agent over another. We have no influence over any fees or charges an agent may require for their services.

This is an optional step, but we recommend you use an agent.

2

You must meet all import conditions before you can bring your cat to Australia.

Check if this is the right guide for you

This step-by-step guide is for cats exported from Group 2 countries. These are approved countries of origin for cat imports into Australia. Group 2 approved countries are rabies-free.

Check the list of Group 2 countries to make sure this is the right guide for you.

- American Samoa
- Bahrain
- Barbados
- Christmas Island
- Cook Island
- Falkland Islands
- Federated States of Micronesia
- Fiji
- French Polynesia
- Guam
- Hawaii
- Iceland
- Japan
- Kiribati Mauritius
- Nauru
- New Caledonia
- Niue
- Palau
- Papua New Guinea
- Samoa
- Singapore
- Solomon Islands
- Kingdom of Tonga
- Tuvalu
- Vanuatu
- Wallis & Futuna

Your country of export is not on the Group 2 list. [Find the right step-by-step guide](#) for your animal and country of export.

If your cat is coming from a Group 2 country, continue through this guide.

Confirm your cat is eligible for import to Australia

To be eligible for import to Australia, your cat must have either:

- lived in a Group 1 or Group 2 approved country since birth, or
- lived in a Group 1 or Group 2 approved country since it was exported directly from Australia, or

- lived in a Group 1 or Group 2 approved country for at least 180 days since its official identity check and immediately before the proposed date of export.

You must also meet:

- all requirements outlined in this guide
- all import conditions on your catdog's unique import permit

You can apply for an import permit when you reach step 4.1 of this guide.

The 180 days in an approved country is NOT a quarantine period.

Your cat can be living with you or someone else in a Group 1 or Group 2 approved country while being prepared for export. They must still undergo a period of quarantine after arriving in Australia.

When you plan to export your cat, it must NOT be:

- under quarantine restrictions
- more than 30 days pregnant
- nursing kittens.

Non-domestic cat hybrids are not allowed into Australia.

This ban relates to environmental protection laws, not biosecurity laws. You will need to talk to the relevant government agency for details.

Hybrid cats NOT allowed into Australia include, but are not limited to, these breeds and any crossbred offspring derived from them:

- Savannah cats: domestic cat (*Felis catus*) crossed with serval cat (*Felis serval*)
- Safari cats: domestic cat crossed with Geoffrey cat (*Oncifelis geoffroyi*)
- Chausie cats: domestic cat crossed with Jungle cat (*Felis chaus*)
- Bengal cats: domestic cat crossed with Asian leopard cat (*Prionailurus bengalensis*)

Contact the Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water (DCCEEW) at exotic.species@dcceew.gov.au. They can provide more advice on hybrid animals.

If an imported cat is identified as possibly being a hybrid after arrival in Australia, DCCEEW may investigate further.

Bengal cat policy change

As of 1 March 2026, Bengal cats are no longer permitted to enter Australia.

For further information on this policy change, please refer to the DCCEEW [news release](#).

If your cat is sick or old

Consider your cat's age and general health.

Sick and elderly animals, and those with chronic diseases may not cope with long distance travel and climatic stress.

We do not recommend importing sick or very old animals. International travel can cause them to destabilise and rapidly deteriorate. Even cats with well-managed chronic diseases can arrive in distress and poor health.

An import permit will not be refused based on an animal's age. Consider your cat's age and how they may handle the journey and quarantine in Australia. Seek advice from your veterinarian if you're concerned.

Cats with special care requirements

There may be conditions that we cannot manage during the post entry quarantine period. Or there may be medications we that cannot be administered. See [Cats and dogs travelling to Australia with special care requirements](#).

Animals may be unable to get medication during transport. As a pet owner, you must consider if it's in your pet's best interests to travel the long distance and stay in quarantine.

Seek advice from the competent authority in your country of export

Each approved country has its own endorsement process and specific documents.

You must contact the competent authority in your exporting country. They will confirm if you are using the most up-to-date, country-specific documents.

Find the competent authority in your country

A [competent authority](#) is the government agency responsible for animal health. This may be a [government veterinary service or similar](#). In Australia, it is us (Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry).

The competent authority must provide official documents for your cat before it leaves for Australia.

We check these documents when your cat arrives in Australia to ensure your cat has met all pre-export requirements.

Find an authorised veterinarian to prepare your cat for export

All pre-export veterinary procedures must be:

- completed in the country of export
- completed by a [government approved veterinarian](#)
- endorsed by an [official government veterinarian](#)

- completed before departing for Australia

This process ensures your cat doesn't bring pests or diseases to Australia.

When you talk to the competent authority in your exporting country, they will let you know:

- which documents or forms you must use
- any local procedures or requirements you must meet before you export your cat
- how to find a government approved veterinarian to prepare your cat for export to Australia
- how to find government approved laboratories for pre-export testing.

Do not risk arriving in Australia with the wrong checks, treatments or certificates.

Talk to the competent authority. Only use a government approved veterinarian to prepare your cat for export.

Read through this guide

We recommend you read this whole guide before you start the import process.

This guide details important actions you must take. This includes applying for and being issued with an import permit. Your import permit outlines the preparations required for your cat. You must meet all these conditions before you bring your cat to Australia.

Share this guide and your import permit with your:

- government approved veterinarian
- and pet transport company.

They will help you meet all import conditions.

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Do this before you start the import process and at least 180 days before you wish to export your cat.

Check your cat has a microchip or implant a new one

Microchips are the only approved identification method. The competent authority in the country of export will use the microchip to verify your cat's identity.

Your cat must have a working microchip before you start the import process.

If a microchip cannot be read or is incorrect in your documents, your cat cannot be imported to Australia.

A [government approved veterinarian](#) must scan the microchip:

- at each vet visit
- before any pre-export blood sampling.

They must ensure that the microchip number is accurately recorded on all documentation, including test samples. This is how we match your cat to its preparations and documents.

Your cat must be implanted with a microchip that can be read by an ISO compatible microchip reader. Generally, microchips with 10 or 15 digits are ISO compliant.

Microchip numbers starting with 999 are not accepted because they are not unique. AVID microchips that are 9 digits long are not acceptable because they are not ISO compatible.

We do not accept laboratory reports or other documents where the microchip details have been amended.

This includes changes to microchip number as well as the collection date, laboratory received date, or results.

If your cat has 2 compliant microchips

Both microchip numbers must be included on:

- the identity check
- the import permit application
- the final import permit
- the veterinary health certificate.

Both microchips must be scanned and recorded at each veterinary visit. They must match all import documents.

If your cat has a compliant microchip and a non-compliant microchip, we will only use the compliant microchip.

If your cat's microchip stops working

The veterinarian should try multiple microchip scanners to read the microchip.

If the microchip cannot be read, a new ISO compatible microchip must be implanted. Then the pre-export process must begin again. This includes all tests, treatments, examinations, and the official identity verification.

Your cat must arrive in Australia with a compliant microchip. It must be scannable and linked to the import permit and health certificate.

If the microchip cannot be scanned, or the microchip number is inconsistent on any import paperwork, your cat may be exported from Australia.

Verify your cat's identity

Do this at least 180 days before export.

Your cat's identity must be verified by the competent authority in the export country.

This step is required to import your cat to Australia. You must complete this step before starting any other pre-export preparations.

Your cat will be eligible for import to Australia 180 days after its identity has been verified by a competent authority in a Group 2 country.

An [official government veterinarian](#) must:

- verify your cat's identity
- complete the identity declaration form
- send the form directly to us.

Each approved country has its own country-specific forms and processes. You must contact the competent authority in your country of export for guidance.

Pet passports, vaccination cards, or microchip certificates are not accepted as equivalent documents.

Identity declarations do not expire. Once received and accepted by us, they remain valid for as long as the microchip is functional and your animal:

- can be identified by the microchip number listed on the declaration, and
- resided in a Group 1 or 2 approved country.

All cats must have their identity verified before you start the import process, including cats under 6 months of age.

If this is done and a permit is lodged before the cat turns 6 months old, the 180-day waiting period before export may not apply.

Returning Australian animals

If your cat is returning to Australia directly from the country they were exported to, their health certificate may be used to verify their identity. We must have issued this certificate before your cat departed Australia.

Your cat's microchip must remain valid and be able to be scanned. The microchip must be recorded for every test, treatment and examination. This includes scans on arrival into our quarantine facility.

See more on [returning Australian animals](#).

If you no longer have a copy of the health certificate:

Contact the [regional office](#) your cat was exported from and request a copy.

If you're unable to obtain the records, contact us at imports@aff.gov.au

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Allow plenty of time to get your permit before your proposed export date.

Apply for a permit as soon as you intend to travel.

Permits can take time to be issued. Most permits are issued in 20-40 business days. It can take up to 123 business days in some cases.

Apply for an import permit

Apply for your import permit through our [Biosecurity Import Conditions System \(BICON\)](#).

Be aware that applying for an import permit does not guarantee you will be issued with one.

We cannot expedite an application for any reason. We understand this may be difficult. To ensure fairness to all applicants, we process permits in the order they are received.

Import permits are valid for 12 months from the date the permit is granted.

See more on [how to apply for a permit](#)

Assistance cats

We are reforming the import pathway for assistance animals to include cats.

In the interim, we can consider import permit applications for assistance cats.

Contact us for guidance on travelling with your assistance cat at imports@aff.gov.au.

Pay in full when you submit your application in BICON.

Import permit applications are not processed until fees are paid in full.

Extra charges may apply if information is missing, incorrect, or if an application is put on hold.

Your import permit is NOT issued.

We may require more details from you before we can issue a permit. We'll advise you of action you can take to meet import conditions. In rare cases, we may refuse to issue an import permit.

Your import permit is issued.

Continue through the steps in this guide.

Meet all import permit conditions

Read your import permit carefully. It includes important conditions you must meet.

Once you are granted an import permit, you must make sure you meet all your import permit conditions.

The conditions will be specified on the permit. This includes specific pre-export veterinary procedures required for your cat. These conditions are mandatory.

Make sure you read all import permit conditions and understand what you need to do.

If you fail to comply with your permit conditions, your cat may be:

- held longer in post entry quarantine
- subject to additional testing and treatment
- exported
- euthanised.

You will also be liable for any costs involved.

Import permits are valid for 12 months from date of issue.

The permit must be valid at the time of export to Australia.

As your cat is coming from a group 2 country, entry is only permitted 180 days after verification of identity (see Step 3.2).

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Do this after you receive your import permit.

Book your cat's post-entry quarantine stay

Your cat will stay at least 10 days in quarantine in Australia.

Cats must spend at least 10 days at the Mickleham post entry quarantine facility. Our quarantine facility is designed to comfortably accommodate cats and meet their needs.

Check rules for stops on the way to Australia

We have specific rules for travel that include stops in other countries.

These rules depend on whether the cat will:

- remain on the plane (transiting)
- be unloaded from the plane and moved to another plane (transshipping).

Make sure you understand these rules when choosing flights.

Transiting

During transport to Australia, cats may transit in all countries. This means the plane can touch down in a country, but your cat must stay on the plane on the international side of the airport.

Transshipping

Your cat may only tranship (change aircraft) in:

- an [approved Group 1 or Group 2 country](#), OR

- these cities in Group 3 countries:
 - Amsterdam
 - Frankfurt
 - Copenhagen
 - London
 - Dubai
 - Hong Kong.

Your cat must not leave the international side of the airport. It must stay under the supervision of the [competent authority](#) in the country of transshipment. It must be in a place that restricts contact with other animals.

It is your responsibility as the importer to contact the competent authority in the country of transshipment. You need to find out:

- whether they allow animals to tranship
- whether they have a facility to hold animals during transshipment
- how long the animals can be held
- if additional conditions apply.

Your cat may not be eligible for import if these conditions are not met.

Consider your cat's travel arrangements

We cannot control how long your cat will be held at these destinations. If your cat is sick or elderly, consider if this is the right decision for them.

Book travel for your cat

You can either make the travel arrangements yourself or use an animal transport company.

You can use any airline to transport your cat to Australia, at the airline operator's discretion. See the International Pet and Animal Transportation Association's website for a list of [animal transport companies](#)

Your cat must arrive directly into Melbourne International airport from your country of export. We do not permit domestic transfers.

If you cannot get a direct flight into Melbourne International airport, contact us at imports@aff.gov.au.

Travelling as manifested air cargo

Your cat must travel:

- as manifested cargo (not in the cabin)
- in a crate that meets the [International Air Transport Association \(IATA\) guidelines](#).

We are not responsible for your cat while they are under the care of the aircraft operator.

Travelling via private or chartered flight

Find out more if you plan to [import your cat via private or chartered flight](#).

You must pay for all transport costs for your cat.

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These must be completed by a government approved veterinarian in the country of export.

Plan early. You need to make sure you complete all treatments and tests in the correct timeframes before export.

Check all timings of tests and treatments as soon as possible.

All preparations are calculated from the [date of export](#), local time in the country of export. For calculating timeframes, the date of the treatment or preparation counts as 'day 0'.

We do not accept laboratory reports or other documents where the details have been amended. This includes changes to microchip number as well as the collection date, laboratory received date, or results.

Contact us at imports@aff.gov.au if you identify a mistake on any of your cat's laboratory reports.

Complete all remaining veterinary preparations

All veterinary preparations must be done by a [government approved veterinarian](#) in the country of export.

Your cat must be fit and healthy enough to:

- travel to Australia
- undergo post-entry quarantine without ongoing veterinary intervention.

Female cats must not be more than 30 days pregnant at the time of export.

We are not responsible for the veterinary and husbandry care requirements for heavily pregnant or post-partum cats, or kittens.

All testing must be done by a laboratory approved by the [competent authority](#) in the country of export.

To find a [government approved veterinarian or laboratory](#), contact the competent authority in the country of export.

We cannot give advice on treatments for diseases

Seek advice from a government approved veterinarian if your cat tests positive to an infectious disease listed in the import conditions.

Some South Pacific Island countries may not have a permanent government approved veterinarian. Contact us if you do not have a local government approved veterinarian. Do this well ahead of your planned date of export. In some cases, veterinary preparations can be completed by a visiting foreign veterinarian.

We recommend you share this step-by-step guide and your import permit with your government approved veterinarian.

Your government approved veterinarian will help make sure you meet all import conditions. This information is also useful to share with pet transport companies.

Check vaccinations

Recommended vaccinations

We recommend that your cat is also vaccinated against:

- feline enteritis (also known as feline panleukopenia or feline distemper)
- rhinotracheitis
- calicivirus.

These vaccinations are not required to import your cat to Australia.

These diseases are already present in Australia and are not considered a biosecurity risk. However, keeping your cat's vaccinations up to date may help protect their health during travel and quarantine.

Treat for external parasites

Start at least 21 days before export and repeat according to manufacturer directions.

To calculate 21 days before the date of export, count the first day the treatment as day 0. For example, if treatment is given 1 January, then the earliest date of export is 22 January.

If the product manufacturer's directions specify a 28-day re-treatment interval, the cat must either be re-treated by the government approved veterinarian on 29 January or be exported to Australia before 29 January.

A government approved veterinarian must treat your cat with an acceptable product that kills ticks and fleas on contact. The chosen product must remain effective against new flea and tick infestations until the date of export to Australia.

The government approved veterinarian may need to repeat the treatment to maintain continuous protection until export. They must follow the manufacturer's directions. Reapplication periods for fleas and ticks (or species of tick) may differ. If so, adhere to the shortest reapplication interval.

At each step of the export preparation, the government approved veterinarian must:

- scan the cat's microchip

- examine the cat for signs of external parasites.

If fleas or ticks are found they must be removed, and the preparation must be restarted.

See [acceptable external parasite treatments](#).

Pet owners cannot administer external parasite treatments.

Treatments must be administered and recorded by a government approved veterinarian.

Treat for internal parasites

Plan enough time to complete treatments before export.

Your cat must be treated twice within 45 days before export. The two treatments must be spaced at least 14 days apart. The second treatment must be given within 5 days before the date of export.

For example, if the date of export is 30 January:

- The earliest date the first treatment can be given is 16 December.
- The earliest date the second treatment can be given is 25 January.
- There are more than 14 days between 16 December and 25 January – this meets the 14-day spacing requirement.

A government approved veterinarian must treat your cat for nematodes and cestodes (internal parasites).

See [acceptable internal parasite treatments](#).

Pet owners cannot administer internal parasite treatments.

Treatments must be administered and recorded by a government approved veterinarian.

Ask your government approved veterinarian about products that treat both nematodes and cestodes in cats.

Combined products that cover both nematodes and cestodes are available in many countries and are accepted for use.

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These are the final preparation activities before you export your cat.

Book a final pre-export clinical examination

Within 5 days before your cat's date of export.

When calculating timeframes, the day the treatment or preparation is completed counts as 'day 0'. For example, if your cat's [date of export](#) is 30 January, the final veterinary health check can be completed on or after 25 January.

Check competent authority office hours and timeframes.

Government offices may be closed over local public holidays and weekends. Make sure that you have enough time to get the veterinary health certificate endorsed before export.

Your cat must be examined for external parasites and clinical signs of infectious or contagious disease. This must be done within 5 days of export by a [government approved veterinarian](#) or an [official government veterinarian](#).

You will need these documents for the final examination:

- a valid import permit
- evidence of external parasite treatments
- evidence of internal parasite treatments
- the veterinary health certificate, if required by your competent authority.

It's acceptable to do the second internal parasite treatment at the same veterinary visit as the final veterinary check.

Get your veterinary health certificate

The veterinary health certificate is specific to your country of export. Different countries may use different certificates and processes.

You must get the veterinary health certificate required for export to Australia from the competent authority in your country of export. The competent authority can provide the certificate and advice on how it must be completed. DAFF does not issue or provide veterinary health certificates.

Depending on the requirements in your country of export, the certificate may be completed by a government approved veterinarian, an official government veterinarian, or both. The competent authority can tell you who must complete the certificate.

This may be done during the final pre-export clinical examination (see Step 7.1).

Get your veterinary health certificate endorsed by an official government veterinarian

Within 5 days before your cat's date of export.

For example, if the date of export is 30 January, the earliest date the health certificate can be endorsed is 25 January. The certificate must be endorsed after the final veterinary health check and the second internal parasite treatment have been completed. They can both be completed on the same day.

The completed veterinary health certificate must be endorsed by an official government veterinarian from the competent authority.

An official government veterinarian must:

- endorse every page of the veterinary health certificate

- give you a seal to be placed on your cat's crate at the time of export
- record the seal number on the veterinary health certificate.

Endorsement of the import permit is not required.

Corrections

Corrections to the veterinary health certificate must be struck through. Corrections must be legible and must be signed, stamped, and dated by the official government veterinarian.

The use of correction fluid on any part of the veterinary health certificate or other documents is NOT acceptable.

It will result in the documents being rejected upon arrival in Australia.

Gather your import documents

Your cat must arrive in Australia with these documents:

- a valid import permit
- a veterinary health certificate.

The veterinary health certificate must be an original document. Copies will not be accepted.

The veterinary health certificate and any required laboratory test reports must include evidence that they have been issued, approved or endorsed by an official government veterinarian of the competent authority. This may be shown through an official stamp, seal, signature or secure digital endorsement.

Send all import documents with your cat.

A valid import permit, veterinary health certificate and relevant documents must travel to Australia with your cat. Keep a copy of each document for your records

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What to do when you're ready to send your cat, and what will happen when they arrive.

Prepare your cat for travel

Your cat must arrive in Australia before their import permit expires.

On the day of travel:

- place your cat in a crate that meets the [IATA standard recommended container requirements](#), including any bedding or other comfort requirements.
- don't place any items, including toys, medication or items of value in the crate (these will be destroyed as biosecurity waste upon arrival)
- seal your cat into the crate using the seal supplied by the official government veterinarian.

In most cases, you will check your cat in at the freight terminal, not the passenger terminal.

Check with your airline to find out which terminal you need to use.

The IATA guidelines do NOT recommend sedating or tranquilising pets for air travel.

This is due to the potential for adverse effects during transport. Most airlines follow IATA guidelines and do not permit sedation. If you are concerned about your cat's wellbeing during travel, seek advice from your veterinarian. If sedation is being considered, please confirm with your airline whether it is allowed.

What may happen during travel

You can find general information on the IATA website, or the website of your chosen airline.

Your cat's crate must remain sealed. The seal must be intact on arrival in Australia.

Your cat's crate may only be opened in exceptional circumstances. Opening the crate will cause the tamper-evident seal to be broken.

If this occurs, the crate must be resealed by:

- an official government veterinarian, or
- airport authority, or
- the captain of the aircraft.

They must also provide a certificate detailing the circumstances. The certificate should be attached to the outside of the crate before departure from the port where the seal was broken.

You can find more information on the [IATA website](#).

When your cat arrives in Australia

One of our biosecurity officers will collect your cat on arrival. They will transport your cat directly to the Mickleham post entry quarantine facility.

You will be notified via email that your cat has arrived safely, within 24 hours of arrival. We will contact you immediately if there is an issue with your cat on arrival.

We will:

- help your cat settle in and get comfortable after their flight
- check your cat to make sure they're healthy and free from diseases or pests of biosecurity concern
- assess your cat's import documents to check they comply with our import conditions.

Your cat will be housed in a large, individual, climate-controlled enclosure. They'll be fed quality food, groomed, and provided with enrichment. We will send you updates on your cat's health and wellbeing.

If your cat does not comply with the permit conditions, further tests, treatments or quarantine may apply.

Cats must stay at Mickleham for a minimum of 10 days.

Any issues that increase biosecurity risk such as incomplete documentation or using unacceptable treatments may result in a longer stay.

Read more about our state-of-the-art [quarantine facilities](#).

Register your cat in Australia

You are responsible for meeting local requirements for cats in Australia. We recommend that you register your cat with a national microchip registry.

Contact your local Australian council or state government for advice on:

- how to register your catdog
- microchipping
- yearly fees
- other legal requirements.

We are not involved in local council and national microchip registration databases.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/cats-dogs/how-to-import/step-by-step-guides/category2-step-by-step-guide-for-cats>